Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 3.1 Guided Notes: Themes and Methods in Developmental Psychology

Unit 3: Development and Learning | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic3.1

Word Bank

Change	*Cross-Sectional Studies*
Nurture	*Discontinuous Development*
Longitudinal Studies	*Continuous Development*
Stability	*Nature*

1. The Three Enduring Themes of Development

Developmental psychology is concerned with both the chronological order of development and the thematic issues that span across a lifetime. As psychologists study how humans grow, they continually circle back to three primary thematic issues:

- _____ vs. _____: How much of our behavior is driven by our genetic inheritance and biology? And how much is driven by our environment, experiences, culture, and learning? It is almost always a complex interaction of both!
- _____ vs. _____: Does development happen gradually and smoothly over time with small incremental changes? Or do we grow in distinct, abrupt stages with clear shifts between phases of growth?
- _____ vs. _____: Do our early personality traits persist through life, or do we become entirely different people as we age? Some traits, like general temperament, remain relatively stable throughout life. Other aspects, such as memory retention, sensory acuity, and social attitudes, fluctuate heavily with age.

Apply It: Which Developmental Theme?

Using the word bank above, identify which theme best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Theme
1	Twin studies comparing identical twins raised in separate households help researchers determine how much of a trait like intelligence comes from inherited genes versus a person's upbringing and environment.	
2	A psychologist observes that a toddler's motor skills seem to develop in sudden bursts — she can't walk at all for months, and then, almost overnight, is suddenly walking steadily across the room.	

#	Scenario	Theme
3	A shy, cautious four-year-old grows up to be a shy, cautious adult, even though many other aspects of her personality, like her sense of humor and social confidence, have changed dramatically since childhood.	

2. How We Study Development (The Methods)

To figure out how humans change over time, developmental psychologists rely heavily on two specific research design methods to control for variables like maturation:

- _____: This method compares individuals of different ages at one single point in time. For example, giving a memory test to a group of 20-year-olds, a group of 40-year-olds, and a group of 60-year-olds on the same day. It is fast, cheap, and gives immediate results.
- _____: This method follows the same individuals over a long period of time to observe changes. For example, testing a group's memory when they are 20, waiting two decades to test them again at 40, and waiting again to test them at 60. This provides incredibly accurate developmental data, but it is highly expensive, takes years to complete, and runs the risk of participants dropping out.

Apply It: Cross-Sectional or Longitudinal?

Using the word bank above, identify which method best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Method
1	A team of scientists wants to compare vocabulary size among 5-year-olds, 10-year-olds, and 15-year-olds, so they test one group of each age just once this month and compare the results.	
2	A team of scientists enrolls a group of newborns in a study and plans to reassess the exact same children's language skills every five years until they turn 25.	

3. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. Researchers debate whether a person's outgoing personality is primarily the result of an inherited genetic temperament or the result of being raised in a warm, socially encouraging household. This classic developmental debate is called:

A. Cross-Sectional vs. Longitudinal
B. Stability vs. Change
C. Continuous vs. Discontinuous Development
D. Nature vs. Nurture

2. One theorist argues that a child's vocabulary grows smoothly and gradually, adding a few new words every single day in tiny incremental steps. Another theorist argues that language ability instead develops in sudden, distinct leaps, remaining flat for a while before abruptly jumping to a whole new level of ability. This disagreement best reflects the idea of:

- **A.** Cross-Sectional vs. Longitudinal Research
- **B.** Nature vs. Nurture
- **C.** Continuous vs. Discontinuous Development
- **D.** Stability vs. Change

3. To study how memory changes with age, a team of researchers tests the exact same group of participants' memory abilities when they are 20 years old, waits two decades, tests that identical group again at 40, and plans to test them once more when they turn 60. This expensive and lengthy research method is called a:

- **A.** Meta-Analysis
- **B.** Longitudinal Study
- **C.** Survey
- **D.** Cross-Sectional Study

4. A researcher wants fast, immediate results on how problem-solving ability differs across the lifespan, and doesn't have the time, funding, or many years required to track one single group of people as they age. Which research method would best fit her needs?

- **A.** Correlational Study Only
- **B.** Cross-Sectional Study
- **C.** Longitudinal Study
- **D.** Case Study

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

Source content adapted from Psych Review Hub — Topic 3.1: Themes and Methods in Developmental Psychology (appsychreviewhub.com)